Bryan M. Litfin, *Getting to Know the Church Fathers: An Evangelical Introduction*. Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos Press, 2007.

In this introductory work, Bryan Litfin (Ph.D., University of Virginia), associate professor of theology at Moody Bible Institute, aims to invite present-day American Evangelicals to explore seriously some of the most significant figures from the first five centuries of Christianity. In so doing, he hopes to inspire a greater awareness and familiarity with these giants of early Christianity, all with an eye toward their capacity to encourage contemporary reflections on Christian faith and identity.

The book opens, quite helpfully, with a map of the Mediterranean region and southern Europe, as well as a timeline of key events stretching from the founding of Carthage to the end of antiquity, or from 800 BCE–500 CE. Litfin then begins in earnest, offering an *apologia* aimed at overcoming the skepticism long harbored by many Evangelicals toward the study of figures in the early church. He establishes several points. For one, he characterizes these fathers (and mothers) as "spiritual ancestors" of modern Christians, people whose life, writings, and thought would lay the foundation for later orthodoxy, and should be viewed with greater sympathy by Evangelicals. He also addresses some common objections Evangelicals might raise to studying the church fathers, namely that 1) they were not sufficiently "biblical," 2) that they were all Roman Catholics, and 3) that they participated in the "fall" of Christianity as it succumbed to cultural and political devolution (pp. 20–28). He provides counter-examples for each objection, and repeatedly refutes these objections throughout the book. Yet more directly and positively, Litfin wants his readers to see that studying the fathers has value because these figures all illustrate well the most essential "thrust of Christian faith," i.e., a focus on maintaining community and right doctrine (28).

Having given sufficient reason for Evangelicals to study the early mothers and fathers of the church, Litfin examines ten such individuals with some detail. He opens each chapter with some contemporary anecdote or issue and through imaginative connections with the past eases his audience into an awareness of the defining factors for each historical figure. For example, in his chapter on Origen, Litfin opens with C. S. Lewis's *The Lion, the Witch, and the Wardrobe*—an example that would likely find a warm reception among his intended audience—to illustrate the power of allegory (141–143). After introducing each figure, Litfin guides the reader adroitly through the historical, political, and theological climates that both shaped and vexed each of the fathers (and the one mother). Where possible, he provides a brief biographical overview, always subtly reinforcing his major points both about each father and about the importance of the fathers generally. Each chapter also includes the more defining traits of the subject's thought, including some perceived

doi: 10.5840/augstudies201344117 161–163

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problems of those views (such as Tertullian's fundamentalism or Chrysostom's anti-Judaism). At the end of each overview, Litfin raises some questions for reflection and provides a short list of several significant works on each father/mother and their historical context. Each chapter also closes with a snippet of primary reading.

While particular chapters might demand fuller explication, readers of this journal will likely have the most interest in his chapter on Augustine (chap. 9). As with all of his chapters, this one focuses more on Augustine's life story than it does on his thought or writings. Indeed, the chapter reads more or less like a *précis* of the *Confessions*. Litfin, however, skillfully introduces aspects of Augustine's thought by way of the biographical overview. Even with this, many readers somewhat familiar with Augustine will come away from the chapter disappointed with the paucity of the discussion on Augustine's thought, which perhaps more than that of any other figure in this overview has played a tremendous role in the history of Christian thought, especially among Protestants and, by extension, Evangelicals. This chapter nevertheless makes clear that Litfin's primary attention is on the *lives* of such figures rather than their *thought*.

As a whole, the work manages to maintain the reader's interest, particularly if the reader is a novice with respect to early Christianity. Some chapters, such as those on Athanasius and John Chrysostom, are excellent introductions to those figures. And despite the author's overtly Evangelical approach, he displays several refreshing areas of care. First, when discussing the Roman Catholic Church (ancient and modern), he is careful not to mischaracterize this tradition even while acknowledging his audience's skepticism about that tradition (23–24). Litfin shows similar care when discussing the development of orthodoxy, noting that what *became* orthodox Christianity was not a *fait accompli* from the outset (see 77–79). Instead, he skillfully guides his readers to a more nuanced view of such key developments in Christian history.

But as with any work, Litfin's introduction is not without its flaws, and here I will raise only the most pressing criticisms. First, while any introduction has to be selective, there are some glaring omissions in Litfin's overview. That towering figures like Ambrose or the Cappadocians receive such scant attention will come as quite a shock to those familiar with early Christianity. Just as problematic is the omission of any other female figure besides Perpetua, whose inclusion frequently comes across as that of a token female—and one whose story perhaps too conveniently corresponds to religiously conservative views of gender.

A second area of criticism pertains to the overall perspective of the book. While Litfin's overall tone is that of writing history, at points the book becomes a modern "lives of the saints." To be sure, the latter is not outside the purview of Litfin's agenda, writing as he is for a decidedly Christian audience. Yet a historian like

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Litfin is surely aware of the differences in approach between these two objectives, and that hagiography will not infrequently skew the historian's vision.

Thirdly, and on a related note, Litfin's attempt to appeal to religiously conservative Evangelicals leads him at times to sidestep some important historical issues. For example, in discussing the life of Perpetua and the role of women in early Christianity, Litfin dismisses scholars who attempt to explore the life of Perpetua (and those of other women) by means of power dynamics in Christian communities, claiming that such a reading "invests the idea of 'power' with aspects foreign to Perpetua herself. The early Christians weren't focused on power as dominance over others, but on the power of godliness" (135). With this statement, Litfin entirely sidesteps the issue of gender dynamics and power in the early church, and one senses that he does so for reasons that pertain more to contemporary issues of gender and power than they do to historical methods. More generally, Litfin writes about "orthodoxy" and biblical interpretation primarily in ways amenable to conservative Evangelicalism. Yet if anything, the history of Christian thought has the capacity to expand the boundaries of what counts as "orthodoxy," to challenge and even upend an audience's presuppositions. To be sure, Litfin's careful study reflects his own understanding of orthodoxy as broader than that found among many Evangelicals, allowing for more diversity of thought underneath the umbrella of "authentic" Christianity. (See, for example, his sympathetic treatments of the controversial figures Origen and Tertullian.) Even so, a more explicit attempt to engage his readers' perspectives on such issues would have been welcome.

These criticisms aside, there are many who will appreciate this book for what it is. Within churches or undergraduate Christian colleges, perhaps even seminaries, this book is accessible enough to serve as an excellent introduction to the study of early Christian history, especially among religious conservatives. The work is clear and well written, never so heady as to be confusing for novices to the field. Yet it is hard to imagine this work having an audience much beyond this, not least because Litfin himself has written with a particular audience in mind. Nevertheless, Litfin will surely win some converts to an abiding interest in early Christian history and thought, and for that his work is to be appreciated.

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